6 seconds. During this period, the swallowing center inhibits the respiratory center of the medulla, halting respiration, thereby allowing swallowing to proceed.

2.1.1.3 Oesophagus

The bolus passes from the pharynx into the oesophagus. Epiglottis (a cartilageneous flap) prevents the entry of food into the glottis, while the food is being swallowed. Tonsils, the lymphoid organs are present on either side of the pharynx. Oesophagus is the muscular tube located behind the trachea in the thorax, which connects the pharynx to the stomach. The function of oesophagus is to transport the bolus into the stomach. At the end of the esophagus, near the juncture with the stomach, there is a circular muscle called the gastroesophageal sphincter or cardiac sphincter. The gastric secretions are highly acidic and contain many proteolytic enzymes. The oesophageal mucosa, except in the lower one eighth of the oesophagus, is not capable of resisting the action of gastric secretions. The oesophageal sphincter helps to prevent significant reflux of stomach contents into the oesophagus. Gastro esophageal Reflux Disease (GERD) is a condition, which is associated with gastric reflux of acid into the oesophagus resulting in heartburn.

2.1.1.4 Stomach

The stomach is a J shaped enlargement of the GI tract that is divided anatomically into cardia, fundus, body, and pyloric part (Figure 2.3).

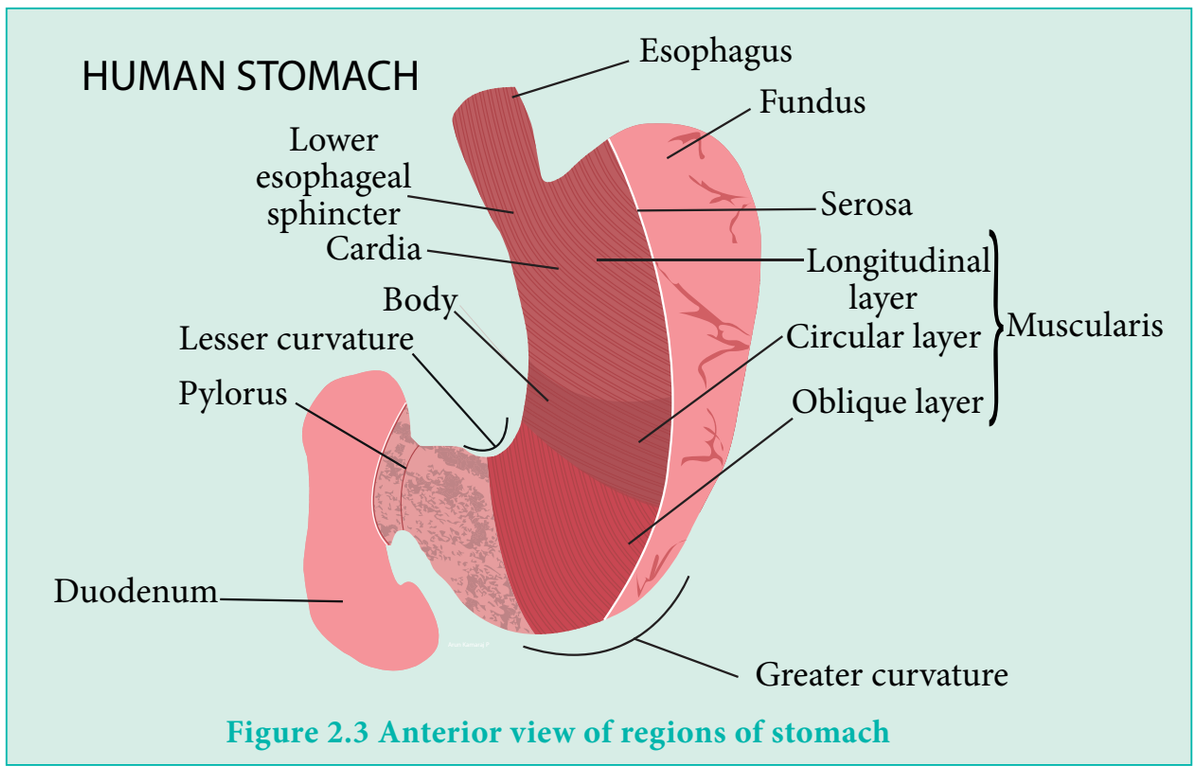


Figure 2.3 Anterior view of regions of stomach

The functions of the stomach are:

1. It mixes the semi-solid bolus with the gastric secretions to form a liquid called as chyme.

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